

INNER SPACE -- FOCUSED EMPTINESS

My beloved friends, you are blessed in body, soul, and spirit. Your path is blessed, every step of the way. You may at times doubt this when the going gets rough. But when this is so, it is not because blessings are withheld from you. It is because you encounter your inner landscape that needs to be successfully traversed. To traverse difficult inner landscapes, it is necessary to understand their meaning in terms of your own being and to thus dissolve the hard blocks you find on your way.

We have occasionally discussed this inner landscape. I have made mention of the inner space that is the real world. The term "inner space" is used quite frequently in your world these days, as opposed to outer space. Most human beings think of inner space as merely a symbolic description of a person's state of mind. This is not so. Inner space is a vast reality, a real world. It is in fact the real universe, while outer space is merely a mirror image, a reflection of it. This is why it can never be quite grasped. Life can never be truly understood and experientially absorbed when it is viewed from the outside. This is why it is so frustrating and often so frightening for so many people.

I can see that it is hard to understand how inner space can be a world in itself -- the world. The reason for this difficulty lies again in the limited time/space continuum of your three-dimensional reality. Everything you see, touch, and experience is perceived from a certain very limited angle. The mind is focused, accustomed, conditioned to operate in a certain direction and is therefore incapable of perceiving life in any other way at this juncture. But that does not mean that this way of perceiving reality is the only way or the correct way or the complete way.

In every spiritual discipline the goal is to perceive life in this other way, the way that goes beyond the outer reflection, that focuses on new dimensions to be found in inner space. This goal may be directly mentioned, or it may never be mentioned as such. But when a certain point of development and purification occurs, this new vision awakens, sometimes suddenly, sometimes gradually. Even the suddenness is only an illusion because actually it is a result of many arduous steps and inner battles.

In nuclear science it has been recognized that every atom is a duplication of the outer universe, as you know it. This is a very meaningful fact. If perhaps you can imagine that just as time is a variable, dependent on the dimension from which it is experienced, so it is with space. Just as there is really no objective, fixed time, so there is no objective, fixed space. Your real being can live, breathe, and move, and cover vast distances within an atom, according to your outer measurement. When the spirit withdraws to the inner world, the relationship of measurement changes just as the relationship to time changes. This is why you seem to lose contact with and awareness of so-called "dead" people. They live in the inner reality which, for you, is as yet only an abstraction. The actual abstraction is the outer space.

When physical death occurs, the spirit, that which is alive, withdraws into the inner world, not, as is often erroneously assumed, into heaven. It does not lift out of the body; it does not float into outer space. If, at times, an extrasensory perception seems to reveal such a sight, it is again only the mirror image of the inner event. In the same way, a majority of humans have for the longest time looked for God up in heaven. When Jesus Christ came, He taught that God lives in the inner spaces, and He must be found there. This is also why all meditational practices and exercises focus on inner space.

A long time ago I suggested a meditational exercise in which you do not think, in which you make yourself empty. Those of you who occasionally try this exercise experience how difficult it is to do so. The mind is filled with its own material, and to still it is not an easy undertaking. There exist several approaches to do so. In Eastern approaches this is usually done by long practice and discipline. This, in conjunction with solitude and outer stillness may eventually produce inner stillness.

Our approach on this path is different. These teachings do not want to take you out of your world -- quite on the contrary. The aim is to be in your world the best possible way -- to understand, to accept, and to create in it in the most productive, constructive way. This can only be done when you fully know and understand yourself. When you traverse, as I said, the difficult spaces which must make you better equipped to function in this three-dimensional reality. Then there is no split between the inner and outer spaces. As inner truth reigns, perception of outer truth increases. As understanding of self grows, so does understanding of the world grow. As you learn to recreate that in you that is imperfect, faulty, so do you learn to recreate your outer life. As you learn of your eternal beauty as a divine manifestation, so does your vision of creation expand and perceives the beauty of the Creator and His creation. As peace within yourself exists, so do you become peaceful with this world, no matter how much undesirable experience exists in your surroundings. In other words, you do not require outer conditions of absolute seclusion in order to reach inner space. You take the other route in which you go right through that which seems the greatest of obstructions: imperfections within and around you. You approach them, you deal with them until they lose their fearsome aspect. This is your path.

Focusing on the inner emptiness can be an additional exercise that is helpful, but it must never be the sole approach to self-realization. Just as dealing with the outer misconditions in your world around you must never be the sole approach to your and your world's salvation.

Focused emptiness grows, both deliberately and spontaneously, as you have removed inner obstacles. At the early stages, you experience just that: emptiness, nothing. If your mind can quiet down, you encounter the void, as it were. This is what makes the attempt so frightening. It seems to confirm the suspicion that there is nothing within you, that you are indeed only your outer, mortal self. This is why the mind makes itself so busy and so noisy -- in order to blot out the quietness that appears to herald nothingness. Once again you need the courage to go through a tunnel of uncertainty. You need to take the risk allowing the great quietude that is at first empty of meaning, of anything that spells life or consciousness.

I believe most of you have experienced already how the voice of your inner God, of the higher self, sends its inspirations through your mind, not necessarily immediately after a meditation

or prayer, often sometime later, often when you think least of it. It is then that your mind is relaxed enough and sufficiently free from self-will to allow the inner world to manifest. It is the same in regard to experiencing the inner universe -- the real world.

Focused emptiness will bring you in touch with all the levels of your being. It allows to raise what was hidden -- the distortions, the errors, the lower self material, and, eventually, the reality of your higher self and the vast world of eternal life in which it dwells. There are many stages and phases to go through. The latter stages can take place only when a certain purification and integration has taken place. Unfocused emptiness is a lessening of consciousness. Focused emptiness is a heightening of consciousness. The former is a tuning out, a vague wandering of the mind that may lead to mindless emptiness. Sleep or other states of unconsciousness are the final stages. Focused emptiness is extremely concentrated, aware, and fully there.

If the inner world is focused on to the exclusion of your outer world, you create not only a split but also a condition in which you forfeit the purpose of your incarnation. How can you fulfill your task, whatever it may be, if you do not utilize your world for that purpose? You would not have come into this dimension if it were not a necessity for you. So you need to make use of it and always bring outer and inner conditions into a meaningful relationship with one another. You are learning on this path to do this. All your outer experiences are brought into relationship with your personality, your various levels of self. And your inner being always reflects and creates your outer conditions, which you soon learn to recognize. If this relating between the outer and the inner is not a constant way of life, the imbalance must create misconditions. So you can see in your world that sometimes a person who does a lot of good works outwardly loses his way just as easily as those who never give others a thought -- perhaps even more, since the latter category is less in imbalance. The outer good intent and good works necessitate an inner focus in order to avoid a disharmonious condition and dangerous split.

Focused emptiness eventually brings the light of the Eternal. Maybe we can categorize certain basic stages although this may be oversimplified. In reality, the stages often overlap and do not come neatly in succession, as I outline it here for the purpose of clarification. (1) You experience the noise and the busyness of the mind. (2) As you succeed to quiet this noise, you encounter emptiness, nothingness. (3) Recognitions about self, connections between aspects of self and outer experiences, new understanding and heretofore unrecognized levels of lower self material become clear. This stage is really a facet of divine guidance and not merely an experience of the lower self. Recognition of lower self is always a manifestation of higher self guidance. (4) There is direct manifestation of higher self messages. It is what you call opening your channel. You receive advice, encouragement, words intended to give you courage and faith. In this phase divine guidance still operates through your mind only. It is not necessarily a total, emotional, and spiritual experience. The manifestation may excite and gladden you, but this reaction is a result of the knowledge the mind has absorbed and found convincing. (5) In this stage a direct, total, spiritual, and emotional experience occurs. Your whole being is filled with the Holy Spirit. You know, not indirectly through your mind but directly through all of your being. Knowing through the mind is really always an indirect knowledge. It is a relayed knowledge. The mind is the instrument necessary to function on this level of consciousness. Direct knowledge is different. This phase has many subdivisions, many stages within itself. There are many, no, limitless possibilities in which the real world can be experienced. It can occur simply through total knowing, which effects every fiber of your being, every level of your consciousness. It can occur through visions of the other dimensions,

but such visions are never merely things one sees. They are always a total experience that affects the total person.

In the real world, as opposed to your fragmented world, every sense perception is total. Seeing is never only seeing, it is simultaneously hearing, tasting, feeling, smelling -- and many other perceptions of which you know nothing on your level of being. In this fifth stage, seeing, hearing, perceiving, feeling, knowing are always all inclusive. They encompass every capacity God has created. And you can hardly imagine the richness, the variety, the limitless possibilities of these capacities.

Focused emptiness is the ideal state to be filled by the Holy Spirit. The Holy Spirit is the whole world of God in all its splendor, in its indescribable magnificence. Its richness cannot possibly be conveyed in human language. There is no way of describing what exists when fear, doubt, distrust -- and therefore suffering, death, and all evil are overcome. Focused emptiness is therefore nothing but a threshold to a fullness that exists only in the world of spirit.

The practice of focused emptiness must never be undertaken in an attitude of immediate expectations. In fact, it is necessary to have no expectations whatever. Expectations are a tension, and tension prevents the necessary state of total inner and outer relaxation. Also, expectations are unrealistic, for it may take many incarnations of development before a human being can come anywhere near these experiences. So any kind of expectations causes disappointments which in turn sets off a chain reaction of further negative emotions such as doubt, fear, discouragement, and so on.

The reason I am talking about this topic is to prepare you for an important practice within meditation. I have discussed this in the past in connection with the various ways of meditation, particularly in regard to impressing and expressing. Much of your meditations have dealt with the former and should continue to do so. This aspect is a cleansing of the mind and using the mind as a constructive tool. The tool becomes a creative agent.

The aspect of expressing has begun to manifest to some degree with those whose channels are open, perhaps only occasionally. But you need to know that there are further stages, phases, and possibilities, and you should approach them with patience, awe, and humility. You should understand that these experiences will open the inner vast spaces in which many worlds, many universes, many spheres exist, endless plains, mountains, seas of indescribable beauty. You should know that these inner spaces are not abstractions or symbolic expressions but are much more real and accessible than your outer, objectified world that you believe to be the only reality that exists. Inner space exists based on different measurements, a different relativity of time/space/movement measurement. Even only your vague and hazy consideration of this concept will change your outlook and create a new approach to your further work on your path.

You need not spend hours practicing focused emptiness. This is not the purpose. But you may attempt it to some degree every time you pray and meditate, after you use your mind to impress your soul substance and align it with divine intent. Your primary aim is still reaching autonomy, in its fullest sense and meaning. You, as a group, have made progress in this respect, but there is still a lot to be accomplished in this respect. Everything depends on this basic prerequisite of reaching autonomy: your ability to respect yourself and discover your values; your capacity for loving and

finding the fulfillment you yearn for; your fulfilling the spiritual task you have entered this earth for; your experience of the living God within and around you; your ability to be a true leader and to be a follower as well; and, last but not least, your ability to let go of the mind and find the inner space which is your real home and which, alone, can convey eternal life to you and thus remove all fears from you forever. You cannot surrender to the will of God unless you have yourself. Nor can you truly find and be yourself unless your surrender to Him is unconditional.

Since this is such a fundamental necessity, we need to spend some time again on discussing this topic although I have said much about it in the past. But I see, here and there, still so much resistance to reaching this all important state of autonomous selfhood. You still crave for an authority figure who will take over for you when life becomes hazardous, when your inevitable mistakes force you to pay the price for them, when your unavoidable imperfections create conditions that you need to experience, explore, and fully understand on all levels. You still crave for the "perfect life" in which none of that is necessary. You still delude yourself that it is possible to avoid mistakes and paying the price for them. This illusion is dangerous, all the more dangerous because it is so subtle and can so easily be glossed over and denied. The manifestation of this delusion can be rationalized -- hence denied also.

Whenever you are unsure and confused about yourself, your environment, events around you, it is a sign that you still suffer from this delusion and thus deliberately avoid growing into full selfhood. Whenever you rebel against authority figures, it is a sure sign that you are still craving for the "right" authority, the superperson who takes over the vicissitudes of life and thus protects you from experiencing your reality.

When autonomy exists, there is no need for rebellion against authority. There is no confusion. There exists a clear perception of what is true and what is false, and therefore there can be agreement or disagreement without rebellion or fearful submission. The road to this clarity and ability to discriminate is the ability and willingness to search, to question, to probe, to be open, to explore. This requires patience rather than quick, ready-made answers regarding any specific issue in your life. But the childish, dependent person abhors the patient way of probing and finding out, for this means labor. The childish dependent person wants quick, easy answers and therefore tends to jump to conclusions. When mistakes are feared, even these quickly reached conclusions cannot be questioned, and so a stiff insistence often bars the way to clarity and truth, hence confusion which breeds commensurate experience. If the connections of how this experience has been created are lacking, life appears too difficult and unfair; so a perfect authority is demanded.

The more strident your protestations for independence, the more suspect this stridency is. The more you need to prove that you are a free agent and not influenced or influenceable, the more likely it is that you abhor real autonomy, that you do not wish to take full responsibility for your life, your experiences, your decisions. The greater the rebellion against those authority figures in your life whom you accuse of denying your selfhood, the more you secretly resent them for not living up to your demands.

What exactly are these demands? They are, as I said, that you be prevented from making any mistakes, from having to pay any price and going through any consequences of errors, distortions, negativities, or unwise decisions. You want an infallible key handed to you that equips you with this kind of magic while still being "free." This "freedom" means doing whatever you want whether or

not it is desirable for your real self or for others. You do not want to experience any frustration or necessary discipline. When these goals are not forthcoming, you resent and blame authority figures, often accusing them of exactly the opposite of what you really expect from them. To be specific, you blame them for infringing upon your freedom when limits are being set forth. You refuse to see that these limits are the limits of reality, of life's laws, and you (unconsciously perhaps) deliberately create a specific confusion in which these limitations and boundaries are being distorted as if they implied enslavement.

I ask all of you to explore this aspect in you if you can find it and to what degree it may still exist in you. Also ask yourself some deeply probing questions. Are you really willing to assume full self-responsibility, with all that this implies? Are you fully reconciled to the fact that you are still imperfect, are unable to avoid making mistakes? Are you truly willing to pay the price for them? The more willing you are to do so, the less expensive this price will be. The price will turn out to be a stepping stone, a threshold, a necessary lesson.

Only by surrender to the will of God can the strength to do this come, can you truly stand in the middle of life as it unfolds around you, never fleeing it, never denying it, never using spirituality as a means to escape from it.

All dualistic confusions will dissolve when your surrender to God is genuine and when your willingness to be an autonomous self is being followed through. You will then no longer be confused about individuality versus community, about self-surrender versus selfhood and real independence. True selfhood creates a social being who is not at odds with his surroundings. On the contrary, this kind of person is intimately connected with others and always contributes to them. The truly autonomous person can be a strong leader, as well as a willing follower because his vision is clear and his selfhood centered in divine reality.

If you go through every lecture I have given you so far this season, you will discover a note of another dimension that has not been touched upon previously. I have opened for you new vistas even if you may not yet be capable of taking direct steps toward attaining these states. But the knowledge of their reality is important for you at this point. What prevents you most from going through these doors is exactly the problem of still avoiding full self-responsibility, autonomy, accountability. Your freedom is directly dependent on that. Your ability to let go in strength rather than in weakness depends on that.

Of course, autonomy, or its lack, is always a question of degree. Many of you are perfectly able to stand in life as far as earning your livelihood is concerned. You may do this in a healthy and productive way that you therefore mainly enjoy. In this area you may also be realistic and accept that there are always aspects of difficulty, boredom, or strife. You lend your best to those times of difficulty and give of yourself generally in your work. This is precisely why you are successful and why you enjoy your work. But there may be other areas, more subtle, less easily noticeable, in which you still want to depend and not be your own self. It is up to you to explore these areas. The telltale sign is how you feel about authority figures in your life, how you can distinguish between whom you can trust and who is not to be trusted. Where do your feelings go? Often it may be the case that your feelings may tend precisely toward those who are not to be trusted, while you view with suspicion those who encourage your autonomy and deserve your trust.

If you cannot trust yourself, you can never know who is trustworthy. And, of course, you cannot trust yourself if you do not know which part of you deserves to be trusted. Only too often you want to insist that the part in you that is most childish, most destructive, most shortsighted, is the self that is autonomous. You want to believe that what feels the line of least resistance and momentarily most pleasurable is also your autonomy. This may occasionally be so, but by no means always. You can only trust yourself if you have learned to listen to that true inner authority that is capable of saying no to momentary pleasure because in the long run it defeats you.

This true maturity, health, and selfhood is the pre-requisite for a healthy, fully lived, and satisfying life. It forms the underpinning of spiritual self-realization. Without this state, spirituality must always bend into some distortion sooner or later, no matter how well intentioned the person may be when he started out.

On the other hand, this state of health and autonomy is not feasible by merely psychological means. Your psychologists have the right idea in mind and strive toward this goal in their approach to their patients. But unless one learns that there are several inner voices to listen to; unless choices are being made as to which voice to trust or to reject; unless these voices are being explored, the goal will forever remain elusive and a beautiful theory. What it amounts to is that the often weakest voice of the higher self, at least at the beginning, needs to be listened to rather than listening only to the loud clamoring of the part that never wants to tolerate any frustration.

It must become clear to you, my beloved friends, that only a community that consists of autonomous people is in itself, as a group entity, autonomous, safe, and creative. In the new age, everything tends in that direction. Your whole society can be transformed to the degree that more and more individuals develop in this way and reach emotional, mental, and spiritual maturity. When all of society, at least as an overall attitude, represents values that express this state, then even those who come from the lowest spheres with destructive intent and/or spiritual ignorance will not be capable to wreak a lot of havoc on your earth. Their influence will dissolve like snow in the sun. This is not so now. It is because too many individuals hanker after the authority figures that allow everything and forbid nothing, that take over all hardships of living.

Deep, intense, realistic contact with the Christ is possible in an extended way only when this state exists in the human personality. Otherwise the road is blocked, the experience inaccessible, the voices confusing. Total surrender to God becomes confusing. The will to surrender to the false authority who permits all and sets no limits to the line of least resistance, who never imposes any frustration, who hold out this kind of utopia, simultaneously creates an inner fear in those who somehow in their inner being know the dangers of such surrender. The weaker ones will surrender to the false prophets, as the Bible says. The slightly stronger ones, who are still partially in this unfinished state but partially strive for real autonomy, fear surrender in all forms. What they really fear and distrust is their own desire for the false prophet who promises what he should never promise. These promises may not be made in so many words, but they are implicit in their messages and reach the consciousness of those who are most vulnerable due to their unwillingness to take over their own life.

So, no matter how much you may be willing to surrender to the will of God and therefore to His guidance in whatever form it may be given you, the resistance to do so cannot be overcome unless you establish full selfhood in all areas of your being. From the evolutionary point of view,

spirit can penetrate matter to the degree that spiritual truth, spiritual law, spiritual health are being established. And the individual's self-responsibility is indeed the key to this. When the self becomes thus stronger, more of the spirit, more of life can penetrate matter. That means more of the spirit can be born into the flesh. So you will see as you grow in stature through gaining selfhood, more of your real being is born into your physical manifestation. More talents may come to the fore of which you had known nothing before. Suddenly a new wisdom manifests, a new understanding and capacity to feel and love, a hitherto unsensed strength unfolds from you. All these manifestations are the real you that lives in the inner space, the real world. As you make room for these aspects, they will push into the life of matter, and thus you fulfill your part in the evolutionary scheme. These attitudes do not grow from outside; they are not being added on to you. They are a result of your outer manifest being making room for the inner, as yet unmanifest being. This happens by the growing process, the hard work you undertake on this path. And after a certain point in your development, it can be helped along by focusing on the inner emptiness until you discover the emptiness is illusion. It is such a fullness, such a rich world of glory that you receive all you need from this inner source and from where it can also be translated into outer experience.

Christ has come in many forms, many times as different enlightened ones throughout the ages. But never has He come as fully and completely, as unobstructedly as in Jesus. You can see that, here too, it is a question of degree how much of the spirit can flow through into matter, how unobstructed has matter become so that the maximum of spirit, of life, of consciousness can manifest as matter. The point will come in evolution when this sphere you inhabit now will yield so much that matter will have spiritualized completely. Matter will no longer be an obstruction to spirit. The void will be filled with life.

By approaching the void without fear, you also remove obstruction to life. Focusing on inner space means, to begin with, approaching what appears as emptiness. Through this void, you reach the fullness of spirit, the totality of life in its pure, unobstructed form. This stuff of life contains all possibilities of expressions, of manifestations. The joy of experiencing this reality is greater than any other. In this joy is your oneness with the Creator, where you and He are one indeed.

You can see, my friends, that nothing in your personality, no aspect of it, is insignificant in terms of creation and evolution. There is no such thing as something being "merely a psychological aspect." Every attitude, every way of thinking, feeling, being, and reacting reflects directly on your participation in the greater scheme of things. By knowing this you will perhaps, once again, find it easier to give your life, your pathwork, your endeavors, greater value. You will learn, once again, to unify an arbitrary duality: spiritual versus worldly concerns.

Make room for unobstructed life, for unencumbered spirit! Let it fill every part of your being so that you will finally know who you really are. You are all blessed, my very dearest ones.

For information to find and participate in Pathwork activities world wide, please write:

The Pathwork® Foundation
PO Box 6010
Charlottesville, VA 22906-6010, USA
Call: 1-800-PATHWORK, or
Visit: www.pathwork.org

The following notices are for your guidance in the use of the Pathwork® name and this lecture material.

Trademark/Service Mark

Pathwork® is a registered service mark owned by The Pathwork Foundation, and may not be used without the express written permission of the Foundation. The Foundation may, in its sole discretion, authorize use of the Pathwork® mark by other organizations or persons, such as affiliate organizations and chapters.

Copyright

The copyright of the Pathwork Guide material is the sole property of The Pathwork Foundation. This lecture may be reproduced, in compliance with the Foundation Trademark, Service Mark and Copyright Policy, but the text may not be altered or abbreviated in any way, nor may the copyright, trademark, service mark, or any other notices be removed. Recipients may be charged the cost of reproduction and distribution only.

Any person or organization using The Pathwork Foundation service mark or copyrighted material is deemed to have agreed to comply with the Foundation Trademark, Service Mark and Copyright Policy. To obtain information or a copy of this policy, please contact the Foundation.